

Blake Shields

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Personal Statement

Senior Data/AI/ML professional, 27 years in. Track record of taking ambiguous problems through design, delivery and the unglamorous operational work that follows. I mentor deliberately and write things down. Core stack: Airflow, MLflow, Spark.

Employment History

Mar 2010 – Current	Senior Applied Scientist Summit Digital - Trained and deployed MLflow models serving 12M predictions per day at under 110ms p95. - Ran A/B tests across 50 model variants; the winning variant added an estimated \$500k in annual revenue. - Built an end-to-end training pipeline on MLflow, cutting retraining from days to 6 hours. - Reduced label noise by redesigning the annotation guidelines, improving validation accuracy by 22%. - Developed an NLP classification system in Spark reaching 88% F1, replacing a manual review queue.
Sep 2003 – Jan 2010	Applied Scientist Cisco - Translated ambiguous business questions into a modelling roadmap with product and finance stakeholders. - Cut inference cost by 15% through quantisation, batching and autoscaling on Terraform. - Productionised demand forecasting models that reduced stock-outs by 22% across 12 regions. - Built the feature store that 3 downstream models now read from, ending duplicated feature logic.
Jun 2001 – Jul 2003	AI Researcher Spotify - Mentored 40 analysts moving into modelling work, with weekly paper reading and code review. - Migrated ad-hoc notebooks into versioned MLflow pipelines with reproducible runs and tracked experiments. - Established offline/online evaluation parity, catching 3 silent regressions before release.
May 2000 – Jun 2001	Applied Scientist IBM - Lifted recommendation click-through by 40% through feature engineering and retraining cadence in Pandas. - Wrote the team's model documentation and review standard, now required before any production launch. - Standardised the team's tooling with Terraform, ending long-running environment drift.
Jun 1998 – Dec 1999	Applied Scientist Vantage Point Technologies - Introduced written design docs and an RFC process, cutting rework late in delivery. - Led a team of 12 through a full replatforming with no missed delivery dates. - Interviewed and onboarded 5 new hires, shaping the hiring bar for the team.

Academic Background

Bachelor, Communications

Meganshire University | 1994 – 1997

Technical Skills

Airflow	
MLflow	
Spark	
Pandas	
Snowflake	
TensorFlow	
AWS	
Kafka	
SQL	
Docker	
Databricks	
GCP	
Scala	
Terraform	
Python	
Figma	

Notable Projects

Match-day predictor

Small model in Pandas predicting league results. Beats the naive baseline; still loses to the bookmakers.

Personal finance tracker

Self-hosted spend tracker built with Terraform. Deliberately kept the data local rather than using a hosted service.

Volunteer Experience

Mentor, a community tech collective - coaching career changers through their first technical role.